

**Speech on “Amazing Vanuatu”  
by Valerie Martinez, Miss Vanuatu, for PITA  
(Pacific Islands Telecommunications Association)  
April 2014, Port Vila**

**Slide on “Amazing Vanuatu”**

Bonjour! I am here today to talk to you about my country, “Amazing Vanuatu.” I am Valerie Martinez, and am fortunate to be Miss Vanuatu.

[Here say a little about yourself if you have not been introduced, for example:  
I am 23 years old, one of a family of 9 children. I work for an insurance company and am studying accounting. I speak French, English, Bislama (our national language) and Tannese (my island language).]

**Slide on PITA sponsors**

First, I want to thank all the many organizations that kindly agreed to sponsor this important event. Without them, we wouldn’t be here. Thank you! Let’s have a round of applause for our sponsors! (APPLAUSE)

**Slide on map of Vanuatu**

So, how many of you had heard of Vanuatu before you came here this time?  
(WAIT FOR AUDIENCE TO RAISE HANDS) Good!

How many of you have been to Vanuatu before? (WAIT FOR AUDIENCE TO RAISE HANDS) Great!

How many of you already love Vanuatu? Raise those hands! (WAIT FOR AUDIENCE TO RAISE HANDS) Terrific!

We will have a good time for the next 10-15 minutes or so, learning a little about our geography, customs, attractions and people. I hope after that you will really love us, and want to come and visit us again and again!

Vanuatu was called the “New Hebrides,” until we got our independence from Britain and France in 1980. Before 1980 we had a pretty strange government.

We had a French and an English court system, two currencies, two governors, two school systems, and even two prisons! Some islands even allowed you to drive on the right and on the left sides of the road!

As you can see in the lower left part of the map, we are north of New Zealand and east of Australia. The map of our country shows that we have 83 islands, of which 65 are inhabited. The first people arrived from Indonesia about 4000 years ago. We now have a population of about 265,000. Most of us are Melanesian and Christian.

**Slide on Flag**

The main symbol on our flag is the sacred circular boar's tusk, on the left of the flag. The boar sacrifice ritual is our most important ceremony.

**Slide on Order of Vanuatu**

The circular boar's tusk is also on our Order of Vanuatu...

**Slide on Chief in ceremony**

...and this is one of our chiefs dressed up in "kastom" clothes, ready to participate in the boar's tusk ritual.

**Slide on VM in Tanna costume**

Women participate in Kastom rituals too, and this is me dressed up for a Kastom dance.

**Slide on sacred stone**

One of our many tourist attractions is a "nasara," or group of sacred stones. These are like Stonehenge in England, but smaller. Here a man on Wala island is explaining that this stone has been sacred to his family for 17 generations!

It is at this stone that his ancestors were married, promoted to chief, and given Kastom names and land rights.

**Slide on land diver preparing to dive**

One of our most famous rituals is “land diving.” This happens on Pentecost island in April, May and June. Men dive head first off of towers up to 30 meters tall.

Here a diver is preparing to dive.

**Slide on land diver just jumped**

Now he leaps out as far as he can. If he just dives straight down, he will be killed.

**Slide on land diver part way down**

Now he is flying through the air.

**Slide on land diver near ground**

And here he is about to land. His whole body will hit the earth at once.

**Slide with face of young man**

Meet one of the land divers, Thierry Bebe. He is only 12, and he has been diving once a year since he was 9. He says his mother “does not discourage him from diving.” And he states that his father “always dives from the highest platform.”

**Slide with bungee jumper from Eiffel Tower**

Land diving was the inspiration for bungee jumping. This sport began in 1987 when some New Zealanders did the first bungee jump off the Eiffel Tower.

Some people from Vanuatu actually sued, and claimed that the New Zealanders had stolen their idea.

But the case fell flat.

That was a joke! You are supposed to laugh!

**Slide with single fire dancer and circle of fire**

Another “must see” in Vanuatu is the fire dance. I understand you are going to see this tonight.

The fire dance reflects our many volcanos – we have 13 active volcanos in Vanuatu, and 10 inactive ones.

**Slide with Mt. Yasur by day**

This is Mount Yasur on my family's home island of Tanna. It may not look too fiery during the day -- but have a look at the volcano at night!

**Slide with Mt. Yasur by night**

Mount Yasur is very accessible. You can drive to the base and hike up just a couple of hundred meters. It is one of the biggest attractions in the South Pacific.

**Slide of view from Summit Gardens**

Vanuatu has world class gardens – this is the fabulous Summit Gardens, with a 60 kilometer view.

**Slide with pavilion at Summit Gardens**

The Summit Gardens have lots of quiet, beautiful spaces, and many gorgeous flowers.

**Slide with long red flower stalk**

**Slide with light pink flower**

**Slide with dark pink flower**

**Slide with small island**

We have 83 islands to choose from...

**Slide of Lolowai harbor on Ambae**

with great yacht harbors...

**Slide of beach**

lovely private beaches...

**Slide with diver and orange ball**

and some of the best diving and snorkeling in the world.

**Slide of old pic of ship President Coolidge**

Here we see the famous S.S. *President Coolidge*, an American troop ship which wrecked on Espiritu Santo in World War II. Later the ship slid off the beach into deeper water. It is now rated as the best wreck dive in the world.

**Slide with two divers and “the lady”**

And here is the climax of a dive on the *Coolidge*. You have the chance to see and even give an underwater kiss to “the Lady.” All at a depth of 42 meters!

**Slide with tam-tam**

We have interesting arts and crafts...

**Slide with resort pool**

...great resorts, and super fishing, swimming and boating. Or – just relax.

**Slide with Port Vila**

This is our capital, Port Vila, where you are now. The town has a population of 40,000.

**Slide with P&O cruise ship**

Port Vila gets about 140 cruise ship visits per year. Most of the cruise ships are based in Sydney or Brisbane.

We are planning to expand our docks to take two ships at once, thus doubling our current capacity.

**Slide with bus and Central Market**

At our famous central market, ladies sell lovely fresh fruit, fish, flowers and vegetables.

**Slide with L’Houstalet**

We have a wide variety of restaurants. I am proudest of L’Houstalet, which is owned by my father, and where I worked with him for many years.

Beside our French cuisine, Port Vila also has excellent Chinese, Indian, Thai, American and Melanesian cuisine.

**Slide with VM and mother**

L'Houstalet is where my father met my mother, shown here. Our restaurant is also historic, since that is where talks occurred in 1979 that led to Vanuatu's independence in 1980.

**Slide with "Tales of the South Pacific"**

Many people have heard of the famous book about World War II, *Tales of the South Pacific*, by James Michener.

**Slide with "South Pacific" poster**

The book led to the even more famous play and movie, "South Pacific."

But most people don't know that this world-famous story is set in the New Hebrides, and the classic island paradise, "Bali Hai," is one of our islands, Ambae.

**Slide with chief and wrecked airplane**

This is the wreck on Ambae of a World War II American fighter plane.

**Slide with LT and plane wreck**

And here is the wreck of a huge American bomber on Espiritu Santo. Vanuatu played a vital role in World War II. Without our islands and the contributions of our people, New Zealand and Australia would probably have been invaded.

**Slide with waterfall and group of people**

Now, of course, everything is peaceful and fun in Vanuatu. Here a group of visitors and locals are enjoying one of our hundreds of waterfalls. But do you notice anything odd about the falls?

**Slide with closeup of waterfall**

Do you see it now? Look in the upper right.

**Slide with crabs in waterfall**

How about now? Yes, in Vanuatu we have crabs that can climb 20, 30, even 50 meters up our waterfalls! Pretty amazing, eh?

**Slide with graph**

In Vanuatu it is not just the crabs that can climb straight up! Our mobile phone penetration has gone up like a rocket. 94 percent of households now have a mobile phone.

**Slide with cable landing**

Our brand new submarine cable is linking our people to the outside world like never before.

**Slide with Independent newspaper**

It really is the “dawn of a new era” in ICTs here in Vanuatu.

**Slide with Ron Box and Fred Samuel**

We have a great investment climate for ICTs in Vanuatu. We have an excellent independent telecom regulator, Ron Box. He is in the middle of this slide. And our energetic government ICT development is led by Chief Information Officer Fred Samuel. He is on the right.

**Slide with flag arrow**

All in all, our country is a very exciting place to be involved in ICTs. It is certainly an appropriate location for this important PITA meeting.

**Slide with smiling girl**

But the most exciting and wonderful thing about Vanuatu is our people – gentle, warm...

**Slide with girl in black**

... and friendly.

**Slide with chief with tusk**

Our customs will fascinate you.

**Slide with girl on boat and shore in background**

Our islanders will welcome you.

**Slide with man walking on rope**

Our men will amaze you with what they can do.

**Slide with big hair guy**

These big smiles mean that...

**Slide with painted child**

We want you to come back to visit us.

**Slide with girl with flag**

So we hope to see you again soon, in...

**Slide on "Amazing Vanuatu"**

Amazing Vanuatu! Thanks!

#end#

V 4; 21 March 2014